

LEFTIST UNIT BALKS HOUSE LOBBY STUDY

Civil Rights Congress Officer Fails to Produce Data — Won't Answer 'Red' Query

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WASHINGTON, Aug. 3—Attempts by the House lobby investigating committee to obtain specific data on the direction and membership of the Civil Rights Congress failed today when William L. Patterson, its executive secretary, failed to produce subpoenaed records.

Mr. Patterson also refused to answer a question as to whether he was now or had ever been a member of the Communist party. "I refuse to answer that question," he told the committee chairman, Representative Frank Buchanan, Democrat of Pennsylvania. "It is a violation of my constitutional rights."

The Civil Rights Congress, listed as subversive by the Attorney General, has not registered under the Lobby Act since 1948.

The records that the witness had failed to bring included the organization's books, list of directors, record of membership and minutes of directors' meetings. The subpoena had asked him to appear with thirty-six items. He said that some of them did not exist and that he felt others should not be handed over.

The witness declared that he did not regard the Civil Rights Congress as a lobbying organization within the scope of the committee's investigation. He later said:

"I'm not disposed at all to be a party to a hunt for the officers of this organization. It is a defense organization and at no time has it been a lobby organization as I understand a lobby organization."

Outline Lists Bills

Drawn out on this subject, the witness said he meant his organization was not one such, "as for example, is the China lobby or the organization that brings us into relations with Spain."

Before the hearing the committee distributed to reporters an outline of the Civil Rights Congress and its activities. The outline listed nineteen legislative proposals that the organization had advocated or opposed.

Chairman Buchanan began reading these, asking the witness if his organization had adopted an attitude on each. He had gone through the anti-lynching bill, anti-poll tax bill, Fair Employment Practices and Taft-Hartley Acts when the witness declared:

"We have taken a position against all legislation considered inimical to the American people, white or black."

He was asked: "Have you tried to influence the policy of the United States in regard to Korea?"

The witness replied with some sharpness:

"Where does that come from in legislation. I'm not here to answer questions willy-nilly. Where does Korea come into legislation?"

The question next shifted to Civil Rights Congress mass train trips to Washington in June and August of 1948. The witness was asked whether these trips were not for the purpose of trying to influence legislation.

He replied:

"They came down here as any American might come to Washington."

Representative Clarence J. Brown, Republican of Ohio, said he understood Paul Robeson came down, and asked:

"Who organized these trips? Did he lead them or did you lead them?"

The witness replied:

"I've been one of those who led them."

"Did they come to influence legislation?"

"We came to speak on legislation, yes."

Today's hearing was terminated abruptly by a quorum call from the House floor. Chairman Buchanan asked the witness to return tomorrow morning.